

01

HISTORICAL RECONSTRUCTION AND THE SOURCE PROBLEM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts pratyakṣa (perception) as the only independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) and rejects unverifiable transcendent entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

That does not make reconstruction impossible; it makes epistemic honesty about the reconstruction itself a mark-earning move.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

One-line memory: Cārvāka is known mostly through its critics, so reconstruct firmly but quote cautiously.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It is nāstika because it rejects the authority of the Veda — and, in the second textbook sense, because it denies life after death. Do not present the "asura-deception" story about Brhaspati as history. Do not conclude from the source problem that "nothing can be known".

ANSWER LINE: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts pratyakṣa (perception) as the only independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) and rejects unverifiable transcendent entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.

02

EPISTEMOLOGY — PERCEPTION AS THE SOLE PRAMĀṆA

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda: perception alone is a pramāṇa; everything else in the system follows logically from this. Chatterjee and Datta: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology." The Cārvāka's test for pramāṇa-hood: knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality". Both external and internal perception are admitted; consciousness is perceived, an immaterial soul is not. Cārvāka denies the inference from consciousness to a soul, not consciousness itself. Truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one. Distinguish laukika (corrigible, practical) from pāramārthika (uncheckable, transcendental) inference; the second is the real target. Śabda in five steps: words heard are perceived → what they mean is unperceived → acceptance runs through a reliability inference → inference is precarious → testimony is not independent. Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved vyāpti, "none would be able to infer anything by himself". The Veda is rejected as the work of "cunning priests" whose promises benefit only the officiants — an epistemic charge with a sociological edge. The single template that kills upamāṇa, arthāpatti and anupalabdhi: each needs an unperceived universal. Sharma's charge: Cārvāka accepts perception and rejects inference from the same standpoint, lacking the samvrti/paramārtha or vyavahārika/pāramārthika distinction that saves Sūnyavāda and Advaita.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Chatterjee and Datta frame the architecture of the whole system on this thesis: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology." Every later denial — of soul, God, karma, rebirth, heaven and liberation — is a consequence drawn from this one epistemic restriction, not a separate act of unbelief.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Chatterjee and Datta present the strongest objection to Cārvāka materialism precisely through internal perception: "do we not have a kind of perception, called internal, which gives an immediate knowledge of our mental states?"

ANSWER LINE: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) epistemology treats pratyakṣa (perception) as the only independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), while accepting inference only as fallible practical expectation rather than certain knowledge.

03

THE CRITIQUE OF INFERENCE — VYĀPTI, UPĀDHI, THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM AND SELF-REFUTATION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a pramāṇa.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally". The attack is on the major premise (vyāpti), never on syllogistic form. Door 1 (perception): all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed. Class-character reply: even dhūmatva and vahnitva cannot be perceptually known, since all instances are not perceived; and universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference. Door 2 (inference): petitio principii or infinite regress; deduction is circular, induction unwarranted. Causal relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect. Door 3 (testimony): testimony's validity is itself inferred; and "if inference always depended on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself." Upādhi: the wet-fuel condition; unconditionality can never be perceptually certified because conditions may remain hidden. Upādhi is a problem of the right variable, not merely of sample size — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it. Self-refutation: the universal denial of inference is itself a universal; and other minds, thoughts and ideas are never perceived. Three replies: no-thesis (vitanā) - softened certainty-thesis - level-distinction.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

This is why the correct one-line statement of the doctrine is: the Cārvāka critique of inference is a critique of the grounding of vyāpti, not of syllogistic validity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a pramāṇa.

ANSWER LINE: The Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) critique argues that inference cannot establish certainty because vyāpti (invariable concomitance) cannot be universally known without circular inference and may always be defeated by an undiscovered upādhi (hidden limiting condition).

04

THE NYĀYA DEFENCE OF INFERENCE — AND A CRITICALLY BALANCED VERDICT

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb. Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Nyāya's reply is architectural: vyāpti is assembled through five distinguishable operations, and the burden of certainty is distributed across them.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb. Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Vyāpti is established by bhūyodarśana, repeated observation, but of a particular disciplined kind.

ANSWER LINE: Answer all three limbs: rejection by other schools, their reasons, and a criterion-named verdict on whether they are justified.

05

METAPHYSICS AND MATERIALISM — FOUR BHŪTAS, THE REJECTION OF ĀKĀŚA, AND SVABHĀVAVĀDA

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Name it as a presupposition, not a proof. Prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni — four elements; and tatsamudāye śāritrendriya-visaya-samjñā — bodies, senses and objects from their combination. Living bodies too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements. The elements are eternal, only their combinations arise and perish (Sharma). Ākāśa is rejected "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika sound-to-substrate inference is refused. Kinvādyibhyo madāśaktiḥ vijñānam — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents. Betel = compositional emergence (leaf, lime, nut → red).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The Cārvāka's best reply is that the soul-hypothesis renames the gap rather than closing it. Pot-and-potter: the objector needs an efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with svabhāva and denies that design is proved. Three labels from the textbook: naturalism (svabhāvavāda), mechanism (yadrchāvāda), and positivism ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena"). Separate the deflationary use of svabhāva (regularity, with no guarantee of future uniformity) from the substantive cosmological use (nature in place of God). Vedāntasāra: four materialist schools identify the self with gross body, senses, vital breaths, or manas. Cārvāka's materialism is anti-inferential; modern materialism is thoroughly inferential.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration that Cārvāka metaphysics is epistemology applied.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

State the explanatory gap and the Cārvāka's reply that dualism merely renames it. Do not translate svabhāvavāda as "scientific naturalism".

ANSWER LINE: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) materialism holds that perceptible bhūtas (material elements) combine according to svabhāva (inherent nature) to produce the world, without requiring ākāśa (ether), a creator, or a supersensible cause.

06

SELF, BODY AND CONSCIOUSNESS — DEHĀTMAVĀDA, AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS BUDDHIST ANĀTMAN (2024, 20 MARKS)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The transmitted formula: caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ — "the person is the body qualified by consciousness"; and, in Chatterjee and Datta's rendering of the Cārvāka position, "What people mean by a soul is nothing more than this conscious living body (caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā)".

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā — the person is the living body qualified by consciousness. Negative argument: "the non-material soul is never perceived." Positive argument: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — bodily predicates attach directly to "I"; on dualism they would be meaningless. Covariation: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease alter awareness. Consequence: death of the body is the end of the individual; questions of rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless". Sharma's objections: swoon and dreamless sleep (body without consciousness) - dreams (consciousness without body) - subject cannot be reduced to object - co-existence is not causation (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) - consciousness is neither smelt, tasted, seen, touched nor heard - consciousness is private - non-existence of the soul is equally undemonstrable. Best evaluative line: the evidence establishes dependence, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause. Memory: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke ātman; Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity; Buddhism invokes saṁtāna, pratītiśāntāna and ālaya-vijñāna. Cārvāka's ground is epistemic; Buddhism's is ontological (prattiyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda) and soteriological (self-belief breeds craving). Cārvāka rejects rebirth, karma and mokṣa; Buddhism retains rebirth, karma and nirvāna without a self. Rūpa is one of the five skandhas — so Buddhist anātman refutes the Cārvāka body-self by name. Puggalavāda (Vātsīputriya) is the internal Buddhist foil; Sadānanda's four materialisms are the internal Cārvāka foil.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Use shared denial but different reconstruction: Cārvāka relocates self into body; Buddhism dissolves self into a causal process.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

He denies a transcendental self and affirms a material one. Do not say Buddhism reduces the person to the body.

ANSWER LINE: Dehātmaavāda (doctrine that the body is the self) explains consciousness as an emergent property of the living body, whereas Buddhist anātman (no-permanent-self doctrine) analyses the person as a causal continuum without identifying self and body.

07

THE REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES — GOD, SOUL, KARMA, REBIRTH, HEAVEN, MOKṢA, VEDA AND RITUAL

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Chatterjee and Datta name adṛṣṭa explicitly among the casualties: "God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like adṛṣṭa) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception".

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The template: X is imperceptible → only inference or testimony could reach X → neither is a pramāṇa → X is unwarranted → X is rejected. Note the gap between withholding assent and denying; the doxographies attribute denial, the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion. God falls twice over: epistemically (no pramāṇa) and explanatorily (svabhāva suffices; "no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design"). Adṛṣṭa is named explicitly among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like adṛṣṭa)". Transmigration requires a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three: Cārvāka cuts every one. Heaven and hell are "the inventions of the priests"; svarga is rejected because it rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death". The liberation dilemma: freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) or freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain); residue — maraṇam eva apavargah. Three ritual reductions: śrāddha and the traveller's food - food downstairs for a person upstairs - jyotiṣṭoma and "why not sacrifice their own old parents". Sarva-darśana-saṁgraha: Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes are "the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons" — quote with a source-caution. The jyotiṣṭoma argument is an argument from revealed preference about what the priest actually believes. Cārvāka is not the only non-theistic Indian school; it is the only one whose atheism is generated epistemologically, and the only one that also discards karma, rebirth and mokṣa. Internal tension worth noting: svabhāvavāda grounds regularity in fixed natures, while yadrchāvāda calls the world's objects "fortuitous products".

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Cārvāka is the only school whose atheism follows from its epistemology and which also discards karma, rebirth and liberation. Do not forget adṛṣṭa by name.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: The Sarva-darśana-saṁgraha summary, as reproduced by Sharma, is the sharpest form of the...

ANSWER LINE: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) rejects God, an immortal soul, karma (moral causation across lives), rebirth and mokṣa (liberation) because none is established by perception, and it rejects Vedic ritual authority as epistemically unsupported.

08

ETHICS AND THE POLITICAL-SOCIAL MEANING — AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS JAINA REALITY (2020, 15 MARKS)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Ethics And The Political-Social Meaning — And Cārvāka Versus Jaina Reality (2020, 15 Marks) is analysed by relating Ethics to The Political-Social Meaning, then testing the relationship through Cārvāka Versus Jaina Reality (2020 and One-line memory).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Hence hedonism. Dhūrta (cunning/crude) versus sukṣiṣṭa (cultured/refined) Cārvākas — the textbooks refuse a single, gross portrait. Evidence for refinement: the sixty-four fine arts (catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ); dāṇḍanti and vārttā incorporated into Lokāyata; some Cārvākas regard the king as God. Vātsyāyana is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism" — but he believes in God and an afterlife and so is a materialist only "in a wider sense". Vātsyāyana's regulation: brahmacarya, urbanity (nāgarika-vṛtti), education of the senses, and the argument that refusing to defer would prevent even sowing a crop. Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline." Sharma's counterweight: "crude individual hedonism"; the school fell through "the denial of all human values"; "the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher." The "ghee and debt" verse comes from the Sarva-darśana-saṁgraha — an opponent's compendium; quote with caution, and extract the argument about deferral under a finite horizon. Chatterjee and Datta apply the word positivism to Cārvāka themselves — "because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and compare its view of inference to the pragmatists and logical positivists. Shared ground with Jainism: both nāstika, both realist about the perceptible world, both reject a creator God. Verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

This Cārvāka ethics may be called, therefore, hedonism or the theory that pleasure is the highest goal.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

He "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term". Do not omit dāṇḍanti, vārttā and the king-as-God report if the question touches the school's social or political meaning. Do not answer the 2020 Jainism comparison with "materialism versus spirituality".

ANSWER LINE: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) ethics is best read as prudent this-worldly well-being rather than crude hedonism: pleasure is valuable, pain is a cost, and action requires intelligent calculation within embodied social life.